

Ford with his late husband, the former fashion journalist Richard Buckley (Above); His movies, *A Single Man* and *Nocturnal Animals*—written, produced and directed by him—garnered great reviews (Below)



billion in 2022. It has been estimated that his personal takeaway was $1 billion. ("By the way," he says with an eyeroll, "the asking price for that house is not what I paid. I did an exchange with another flat I owned in London.") He goes on, in quite boggling detail, to describe how he owns "eight houses, four of which are for sale", some of which are in the States, others in London. Some are "the archaeology of a past life. Now I'm creating a new life, a new place, new house, new everything."

Everybody associates Tom Ford with his Gucci years. All that sexy, spike-heeled slinkiness—as well as the still-outrageous Gucci G he had shaved into Carmen Kass's pubic hair in a 2003 advert—has been rediscovered by young people who were babies at the time, relevant again in this current era of "naked" dressing and Y2K trendiness. "It was simple. But the right simple for the time," Ford says.

In a way this was all a stylistic throwback to the late 1970s, played through the memories of Studio 54 that imprinted on Ford as a young student in New York, the time he came out. It was that, and dropping in on Halston's ultra-modernist Upper East Side townhouse at 101 East 63rd Street with a friend in Andy Warhol's entourage, that sealed his perma-style forever. "I copied everything, the long, low grey couches, everything, from Halston's apartment for the Gucci store design." I strongly remember the feeling of enticement to lounge around those stores as if they were nightclubs. (Ford loved the actual Halston place so much that he bought it in 2019.)

He's frustrated, though, that some may overlook what he believes was, "my best work, my most mature, at Saint Laurent". That's in the same breath as admitting that those years designing both Gucci and Saint Laurent "nearly killed me". Even more underestimated is the much longer-lasting part of Ford's legacy to the fashion world. In 1999 he became a chief architect—with his Gucci CEO, Domenico De Sole—of Gucci Group, which went on to become one of the two leading luxury conglomerates that dominate fashion today.

Under Ford, Gucci was going so wildly well—sales had jumped 90 per cent —and François-Henri Pinault's PPR bought a welcome $3 billion stake in the business. Ford then hand-picked Saint Laurent, Alexander McQueen, Balenciaga, Bottega Veneta and Stella McCartney to be purchased. "I thought, which designers am I jealous of?" Among them was Nicolas Ghesquière, who was incredibly hot at Balenciaga, and Lee McQueen, who jumped ship from LVMH's Givenchy to join in 2000. "Lee was a genius. I am a commercial designer. I don't pretend to be anything but, except that I have, I think, an elevated taste level that appeals to a lot of people. I have a great sense of timing, but I am classic at the core and a commercial designer. But Lee was an artist who expressed his artistry through his clothes. There's a difference."